Lucky Man

By Michael J. Fox

Gainsville, Florida - November 1990

I woke up to find the message in my left hand. It had me trembling. It wasn't a fax, telegram, memo, or the usual sort of missive bringing disturbing news. In fact, my hand held nothing at all. The trembling was the message.

INTRODUCTION

When the symptoms of his Parkinson's disease are at their worst, Michael J. Fox can't write. Or speak. Or stay still. With medication, these effects can be masked for short periods. It's during these times that he wrote Lucky Man: A Memoir,

MICHAEL: I was feeling a little disoriented. I'd only been shooting the movie in Florida for a week or so, and the bed in the hotel suite still came as a bit of a shock each morning.

That's when I noticed my pinkie. It was twitching, trembling, auto-animated. How long this had been going on I wasn't exactly sure, but I was surprised to discover that I couldn't stop it. Weird-maybe I slept on it funny.

The trembling had been going on for a few minutes with no sign of quitting and what had begun as curiosity was now blossoming into a full-fledged worry.

I found myself wandering the halls of New York City's Mount Sinai Hospital. White jacketed nursed and doctors scurried back and forth through the corridor. Any one of them would have recognized the name of the physician I

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was looking for, but that was the problem: they were also just as likely to recognize me. I didn't want any gossip about why Michael J. Fox was seeing one of the preeminent neurologists in North America.

The nurse at the front desk showed me into the examining room, and as I was shedding my coat and baseball cap, she noticed the shaking in my left hand.

NURSE: It's ok . . . You don't have to be nervous.

MICHAEL: Confused for a second, I suddenly realized she was talking about the tremor. (to nurse) Oh.That's…that's why I'm here. In a neurologist's office, I mean. After a second of mutual embarrassment, she left, closing the door behind her. Minutes later, it opened again, and walked in the legendary neurologist himself.

DR. JOYCE: Essential tremor, maybe. Possibly something else, but you're here, so let's have a look."

MICHAEL: "Finally," I thought. "We're going to get to the bottom of this. This guy knows what he's talking about."

The most paranoid fantasy I could think of would not have prepared me for the two words the neurologist bludgeoned me with that day: Parkinson's disease.

Recollecting my exact response to this is difficult. My symptoms showed up in my late twenties! How could I possibly have this old person's disease? The air sucked from my lungs, my left arm was shaking clear up to my shoulder. Why was he doing this to me? What was I going to tell Tracy? I looked up at the doctor and stared; he was so composed. Tough for him, I bet, dropping this on a guy my age. He was really very good…I hated his guts!

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As I stepped out of the door of his office building and onto the rain-soaked streets of mid town Manhattan, it was as if I were entering a whole new world, but the only profound change was not around me, but within me. I had to get home though. Hailing a cab and the ride itself would be slow going. That was ok-I needed every second to sort out what just happened and how I was going to explain this to Tracy, my mother, family, and the rest of my friends. It wouldn't be enough time.

I let myself into the apartment. I could smell dinner cooking in the kitchen and hear my son Sam giggling. I couldn't go in there and face him at the moment. Tracy entered from the kitchen and I met her in the foyer and silently motioned her to the bedroom. As she followed me, I could feel her curiosity escalating toward panic.

In the bedroom is where I told Tracy. Tracy, stunned and frightened, cried. At the same time she was so present, so loving…In sickness and in health I remember her whispering, her arms around me. Typically my first instinct to Tracy: It'll be ok; to myself: what will be ok?! I have Parkinson's disease!

As it was, each week's show presented a brand new set of creative and physical challenges. Could I count on my body to respond in performance the same way it had in rehearsal? By now I could see that the strain I put myself through by trying to be funny was exhausting. Whatever I appeared to be doing onstage, I was, in fact, doing something else: hiding symptoms with a repertoire of little tricks and distracting maneuvers. Many days I had to concentrate more on my physical relationship to the scene unfolding around

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me than to emotional, comedic, or dramatic content. All the while I was doing the math-how long since the last pill? How long until it wears off? And at what point in the show will I have to take another one? "Please…let it be during a scene I'm not in."

If the warning came when I was in the middle of a four-to-five minute scene, there wasn't a thing I could do to stave off the return of my symptoms. If a studio audience were to detect a tremoring of my arm, a slowing of my speech, or a rigidity of my movements, it would undoubtedly betray the fact that something was wrong and that something would be decidedly unfunny.

This became one of my greatest fears; just making an audience laugh remained one of my greatest pleasures.

So I did everything I could to make sure the audience didn't know I was sick. I have always thrived on my relationship to the audience, and feared taking any risk that would distract or detract from it. Timing a joke depends on the audience being with me, and if their attention is lost even for a second while they are watching my arm or a hitch in my gait, then I've lost them. If an audience didn't know what I was dealing with, they wouldn't know what to look for, so I still had a shot at making them laugh. But if they already knew that I was battling an incurable disease, would they still go along for the ride, or would they be watching for symptoms and feeling sorry? Can sick people be funny?

I was beginning to realize that this was what was keeping me from telling people that I had Parkinson's disease. Over the past seven years I had experienced so many highs and lows, and had finally set about facing my

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fears. The distance my disease had put between me and the people I care about had been narrowed, but what about the audience? Until I felt ready to tell them my story, my life would never be fully integrated and as happy.
I can vividly remember all those nights when the studio audience had to wait for my symptoms to subside. I'd be back stage, lying on the dressing room rug, twisting and rolling around. When that approach failed, I'd spruce up the walls with fist sized holes, the graffiti of my frustration! How much longer could this go on?

I entered into Joyce's office on Friday morning. I had a show a show to do that night.

(To Doctor) I've had this feeling lately One I haven't had in years. That old feeling like I'm waiting for the other shoe to drop. (to audience) Joyce was quiet

DR. JOYCE: Michael, you have Parkinson's disease-the other shoe dropped a long time ago.

MICHAEL: Almost as if I had walked into a hug, I immediately felt enveloped in a wave of emotion, not of sadness, but of relief and pride. Joyce was right. The other shoe had already dropped, and I survived. There was nothing left to fear. It was time, I was ready.

Coping with the relentless assault and the accumulating damage is not easy. Nobody would ever choose to have this visited upon them. Still, this unexpected crisis forced a fundamental life decision: adopt a siege mentality -- or embark upon a journey. Whatever it was - courage? acceptance?

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wisdom? -- that finally allowed me to go down the second road (after spending a few disastrous years on the first) was unquestionably a gift - and absent this neurophysiological catastrophe, I would never have opened it, or been so profoundly enriched. That's why I consider myself a lucky man.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier

NOTE: Check here for a list of symptoms and additional information about Parkinson's Disease:
http://www.pdf.org/symptoms

Actor should adopt worsening symptoms through the course of this selection to demonstrate the physical and verbal impairments suffered by people who have Parkinson's.

A video about Michael J. Fox which demonstrates some of the physical tremors experienced by the illness is available at
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ECkPVTZlfP8

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